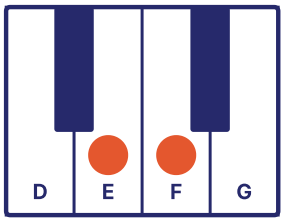
PART I · PITCH · 7

Counting intervals

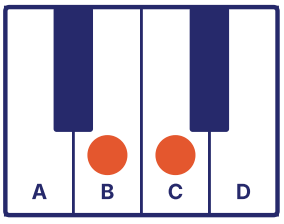
Music moves in distances: a tiny step, a bigger step, a leap. Any distance between two notes is an **interval**. The smallest is the **semitone**, and bigger ones each get a number.

THE SECRET

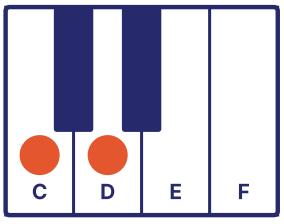
The very next key is a semitone; two make a tone. For an interval, count the notes, both ends included.



E–F
nothing between: a semitone



B–C
nothing between: a semitone



C–D
C♯ between: a tone

Best friends: nobody between

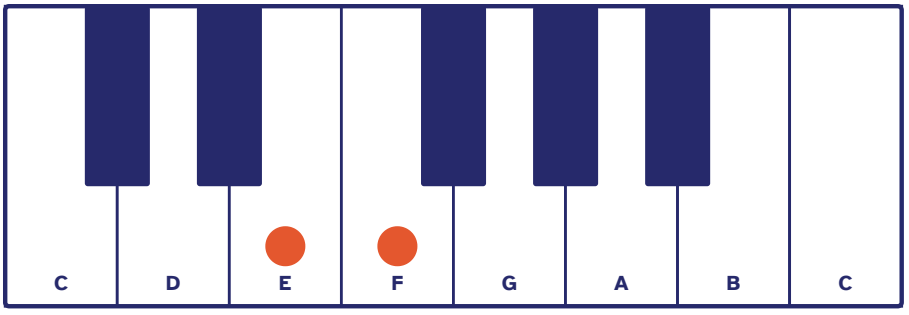
Think of your best friend sitting right next to you, with nobody in between: that is a **semitone**. On the white keys two pairs are already best friends, with **no black key between**: **E–F** and **B–C**. Everywhere else a black key sits between two white keys: one key between, a **tone**.

THE RULE

Semitone: the very next key, with nothing between: white to white (E–F, B–C), white to black, or black to white. Tone: exactly one key between.

EXAMPLE 1

Tone or semitone?

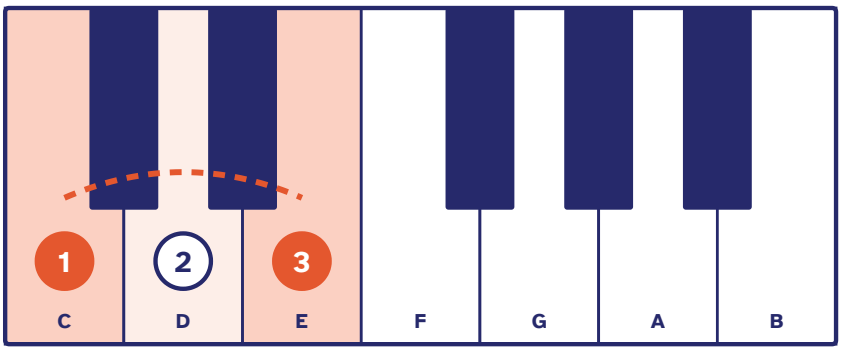


1. **Look between the red keys:** is there a black key?
2. **No black key** means they are next-door keys.
3. **Now try C and D**: is there a black key between?

E–F is a **semitone** (next door). C–D has C♯ between: a **tone**.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

Intervals: count the notes

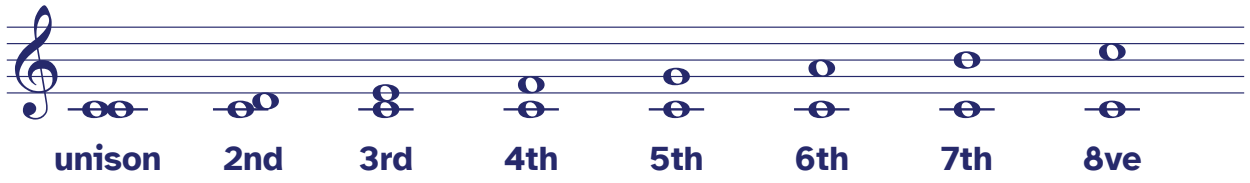


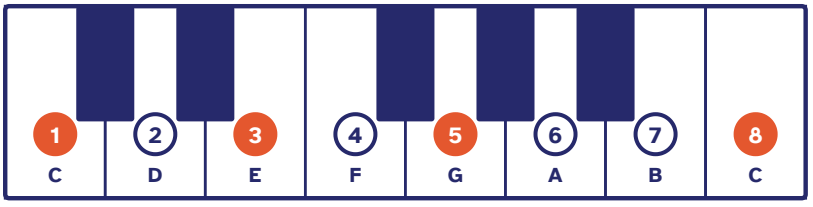
C to E: count the notes, 1 2 3: a 3rd

THE RULE

Count the letters for the number: start at 1 on the first note and count white keys, or lines and spaces, never the black keys. C to E is C D E: 3 notes, a 3rd. Sharps and flats never change the number.

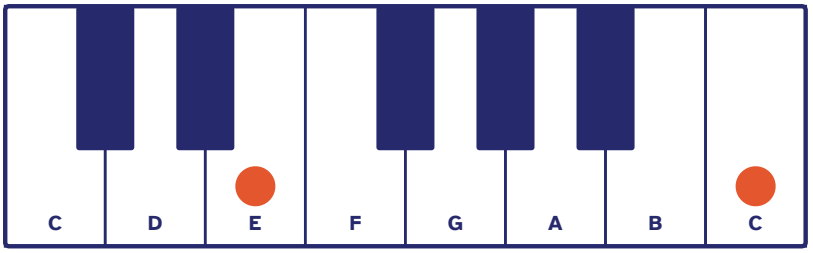
Interval numbers from C





EXAMPLE 2

Name an interval on the keyboard



1 **Find both red keys:** E, and the C above it.

2 **Count the notes** from E: E is 1 ...

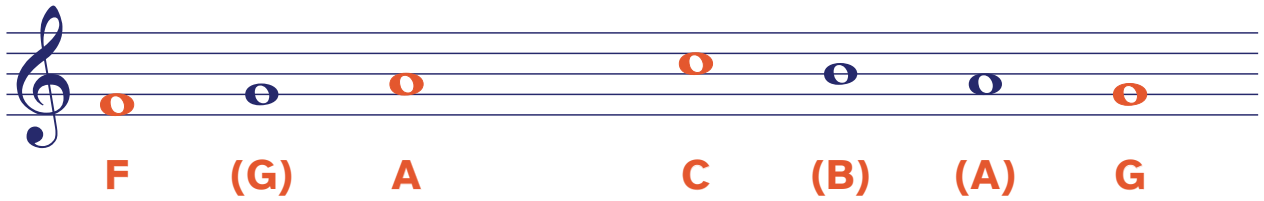
3 **Stop on the C.** What number is it?

E F G A B C is 6 notes: a **6th**.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

How far apart are these notes?

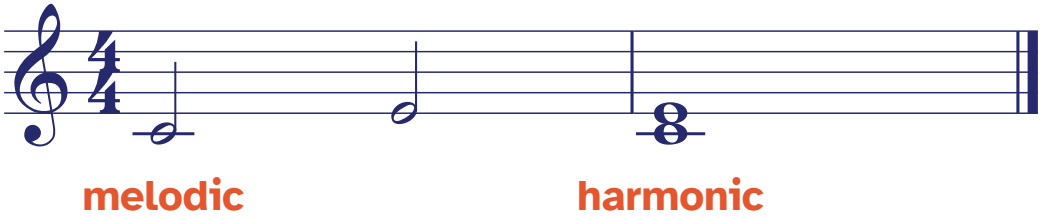


1. **Call the first note 1:** here F is 1.
2. **Count every letter** up to the second note.
3. **Going down works the same:** start at 1 on the top note and count down.

F G A is 3 notes: a **3rd**. C B A G is 4 notes: a **4th**.

EXAMPLE 4

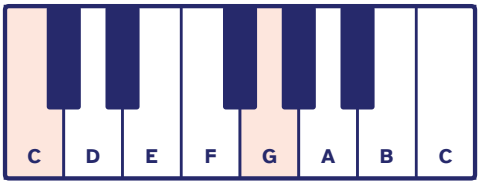
Melodic or harmonic?



1. **The first bar:** C, then E, one after the other.
2. **The second bar:** C and E at the same time.
3. **Count the notes** in each.

Both are a **3rd**: **melodic** when played one after the other, **harmonic** when played together.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Thumb on C, finger 5 on G.

Your hand is a ruler: thumb to little finger on white keys is a 5th. Play it, then thumb to finger 3: a 3rd.

TRAP

× Counting only the gaps: C to E is 3 notes, not 2 gaps. And a sharp or flat never changes the number: C to G♯ is still a 5th.

SEE ALSO
Major, minor and perfect p. 45 · Major scales p. 93

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 13–14 · Online: Intervals · Tones & Semitones